

Prologue

What is a weirdo?

Oftentimes, the term ‘weirdo’ was used as a thoughtless insult against socially awkward children. However, if you actually read a book or two every now and then, you’d eventually discover that Weirdo’s are much more incredible than that. They’re more common and useful than you think.

Some folks call them monsters; but truthfully speaking, only the most dangerous, vicious weirdos would be considered *monsters*. Those ones are a vocal minority. They definitely don’t represent all who wield the title. At the end of the day, Weirdos are just people who don’t think or talk or look the way we do. However, if they smell bad, keep your distance. They’re probably not a Weirdo; Instead, they’re likely someone with poor hygiene habits. Carry on.

Chapter 1

Orange Soda

There was no chance in the universe that Penny Stracciatella could ever like me back.

That phrase stubbornly repeated itself in Cody’s mind as he made his way up. He was climbing the ladder on a decrepit gas station store, like he had done a hundred times. It was a shock that the cheap plywood and metal on the store awning could hold his weight. Cody Overture was as thin as a breadstick, but even his scrawny body tempted gravity while on top of that shack.

As he scratched his messy blonde hair, loose strands got all over his sweater. It was a salmon sweater, a salmon-colored top with a picture of a salmon fish to be more specific. It was his favorite shirt, so he made sure to not get it wet from the awning. Every inch of the rooftop was wet thanks to a recent storm. School was even cancelled due to the mudslides from the heavy rain. While most of his classmates were seemingly out having fun with each other, he was risking a broken neck just to sit on a rooftop and gaze at the Lumberland Forest.

The setting sun cast a shimmering glow over the luscious, wet trees that stretched across the mountainous terrain. The result was a golden hue on the whole forest. It was a sight he’d never grow tired of. While taking in the sights, he cracked open a cold bottle of fresh orange soda.

Especially now, he needed this. As far as he knew, relaxing by an ethereal sunset was the best cure to a heart that was ripped to shreds.

All his thoughts suddenly became empty as a boastful windgust rushed past the ponderosa pines that bordered his homely town. The folks who lived here were strange people, modestly speaking. Most passerbies driving through town saw them as quirky. And compared to the residents, Cody felt he was odder than most of them. While his classmates were thinking of college, Cody was thinking about finding buried treasure. While his neighbors were thinking about lawn decorations, Cody was thinking about barricades from wild animals. It was already an issue that Cody lived in a weird town... but to be the weirdest kid in Lumberland, Colorado was quite another. It also hurt his chances with finding a date to the Spring Dance at his school.

Thankfully, there was only one girl in Cody's heart. His old classmate, Penny.

Penny Stracciatella was the kind of person that just made everything easier. Conversations were less nerve-wrecking. Problems were solved faster with her. And most importantly, her kindness came at a cost. She drove the truck that delivered snacks and drinks to the gas station store Cody worked at. And every time he would sign off a delivery, she'd leave him a spare bottle of orange soda. It was his favorite. He didn't even need to say it for her to know—

“Cody!! What are you doing up there?”

It was Ria Kumar. She was the cashier and assistant manager of the gas station. Her mom was the manager. It looked like a clear case of nepotism, but Ria clearly took her job more seriously than her own mother. Despite being only a year older than Cody, she acted like she was a decade ahead of him.

“Oh hey, Ria,” said Cody, nervously waving, “I'm just enjoying the sites of our beautiful nature surroundings...”

“Right. Yeah, my mom isn't going to pay for your injuries because you wanted to enjoy nature. Get down.”

Ria was a tiny human, but Cody was still terrified of her. She had enough fight in her to outmatch a whole football team — in spirit at least.

Cody sighed and stood up from his resting spot. Before he could step down the ladder, he noticed a ruffle in the distant trees. Soon after, a murder of crows fled from the site. He hadn't seen crows in Lumberland for a long time. There must have been something scaring them. Suddenly, he saw it. A tall shadowy figure resemblant of a headless vulture was sitting on top of the crown of a different tree. It didn't seem to notice him. Before this creature could turn and lock eyes with Cody, he ducked and descended down the ladder.

“Hey, I have a question,” said Cody.

“Hold on.” Ria stretched her arm out as if she was physically halting him from speaking. “I have a question for you first.”

Cody nodded, having safely landed on the ground.

Ria looked left then right; and then with a cross expression, she asked, “Did you really ask out Penny?”

“I didn’t ask out anyone- w-wait, who told you that!?”

“My mom said you were flirting with a delivery girl behind the building.”

Cody could feel himself shrinking into his clothes. Not only was he rejected by Penny, but now there was an audience to it.

“I didn’t FLIRT with anybody. I asked MY FRIEND if she wanted to hang out. And her response was to turn into an out-of-order slot machine. She started spewing all these random excuses.”

“Interesting word choices... What were her excuses?”

“Oh she had work. And she’s gonna be going on vacation that week. She thinks she’s gonna be sick tomorrow.”

“Well, if she’s gonna be both sick AND working, that’ll be bad for business. I could ask my mom for another driver to come in next time.”

“No, don’t punish her for establishing a boundary,” said Cody.

“Boundary? What is she, my landlord?”

“Just please keep on running the shop as usual. I promise it won’t be awkward.”

“This conversation is awkward.”

“Not to me. It’s actually nice to open up-”

“-Cody, I’m your team lead, not a get-well card. This talk is uncomfortable.” said Ria. “As long as she doesn’t file a complaint, you’ll be fine. So, um, get back to work.”

“She won’t complain. And I’m not scheduled today. I’m here to look at the trees.”

“Then look at the trees away from here... please. You’ll get hit by a road tripper.” Ria sympathetically patted Cody on the shoulder before retreating back to the store.

Moments later, rain started pouring again. Even though the sun was still out the golden hour of evening, the clouds in the sky still wanted to drench Lumberland.

“Great timing, God.” Cody groaned.

The red sun sunk slowly past the hills that bordered the town. Its blanketing trees glistened from the evening sprinkle as murky streams rolled down the rocky slopes . Cody kicked down splotches of mud as he trudged down the forest trail. This was the path he always used to get home - so he knew it well. Regardless, it wasn't wise for anybody to travel in the woods alone at night... even the locals... especially when they were emotionally distracted. Before another downward-spiraling thought about lost romance could cross Cody's mind, another hustle and bustle from the trees sounded off. This time, it was louder and closer. On instinct, Cody looked up. And sure enough, more crows were gunning for the sky. Their screeches echoed across the dirt trail. Cody frowned. He knew what was causing this tree rustle, and he was probably the only one in town who had a clue on what it was.

“Ugh. Please don't be a monster.” Cody muttered to himself.

Not many people knew about Lumberland's strange reputation. That's because government agents and powerful people poured out barrels of money to keep it hidden. Despite the town's quaint appeal to travelling Americans, it had a secret more absurd than all of its quirks combined. Long ago, this place used to be filled with vicious monsters invisible to the regular human eye. And it just so happened that Cody Overture and his family were some of the select few humans in the world who could see them. Truth be told, he had yet to see a real monster for himself. However, it seemed like that was all about to change.